Special Called Workshop
Water Conservation
Town of Thunderbolt
July 14, 2021
5:30 pm

Mayor Goette called the Special Called Meeting to order at 5:32 pm. In attendance: Mayor, Beth Goette and Council Members Dana Williams, Dave Crenshaw, Lawrence Ward, Ed Drohan, John Henry and Brooks Barbaree. Staff in attendance: Town Administrator, Bob Milie; Town Attorney, Charlie Barrow; Public Works Manager, Oscar Crosby and Town Clerk/Zoning Administrator, Deatre Denion.

Mayor Goette turned the meeting over to Council Member Drohan. He began with thanking all those who have sat on Ad Hoc Committee for Water & Sewer. The Ad Hoc Committee for Water and Sewer has functioned for nearly 8 years as a prime motivator for successful structural changes in our Water and Sewer infrastructure. The unified support of the Town Council has led to significant improvements in terms of our infrastructure and therefore provided the citizens of the Town of Thunderbolt with a solid foundation for the future. Our efforts towards the implementation of conservation of water resources hasbeen primarily educational, utilizing the monthly billings to advise and encourage residents regarding effective conservation practices.

The following categories provide a central structure for expanding public knowledge and participation in our goal for effective use of water resources now and in the future as a part of a bold and necessary plan for the long-term viability of our water and sewer system and therefore the Town of Thunderbolt.

1) Implement responsible and fair water rate structures.

Establish the "true cost" of the water supply for the Town ofThunderbolt in real time so that fees for water services match the costs. Over the years we have made good guesses on how much water cost us. The Town needs to take a look at the net income of water services. It was in the negative for years. Basically, using SPLOST to get to point A to point B to maintain or grow the system. Also, the Town has a situation arising with the reduction in withdrawals from the Floridian Aquifer. The town will be upside town in its usage. There needs to have a strong tiered-rate structure with affordable prices for those who use water efficiently and significantly higher water rates for customers who use excessive amounts of water. This rate structure should provide the opportunity for consumers to adopt "Conservation Friendly" choices that reflect improved conservation efforts on their part that will in turn be reflected in a preferential water rate. Water usage in June of 2021 pumped 8.5 million. With the required reductions, it will drop down to 6 million. This will increase water purchase from Savannah close to 40%. Raising total to $700,000 to pay for the water from Savannah. Regards to this first segment, the Towns software program for billing does not allow us to capture cost in real time. i.e. pump failure. The Town will either has to anticipate the cost or attempt to create an aggressive water conservation program to reduce the need for Savannah water.

2) Establish aggressive water conservation goals. The Town should implement a toilet replacement program. It should be established for residential for both owner-occupied and rental

properties. The Town should fund water conservation efforts, adopt an outdoor watering ordinance and expand education to the public.

3) Thunderbolt needs to be responsible and bold in terms of our conservation goals. There needs to be a "Conservation Friendly" status of customers who receive the best base rate in our system. The Town needs to explore the implementation "graywater" options. There is mixed information on this. It will reduce the sewage use. The town is hindered by not having a wastewater treatment plant. The sewer lines are designed for the three PPPs. Anything else cost the Town in repairs. The Town needs to move to composting to reduce our footprint. In Thunderbolt of about 2600 people, 45 tons of trash is produced per year. The average person creates a pound of food waste per day. It goes down the drain or in the Landfill. Either Way, we pay the price. The Town needs to initiate creative rethinking of how the Town manages waste management in Thunderbolt. There needs to be a reduction in damages to the sewerage infrastructure and utilization cost paid to Savannah by implementing Town-wide composting. Redirect costs to composting as a way to reduce our "garbage footprint". The Town bills for only water being used, not the actual wastewater amount. The Town subsidizes the other. Council Drohan and staff have started a conversation with COR, a composting company that has made arrangement with mainly hotels to turn it into soils. There was a meeting with Town Administrator, Council Member Henry, Council Member Drohan, COR and Ben Wall, Atlantic Waste. At the end of the meeting, it was clear Thunderbolt was not doing anything but they can move forward voluntarily. They have three restaurants and Wesley Church that have agreed to be a collection site. Connect Magazine is running an article on the program. Finches, Tubby's and Coach's are the restaurants participating in the pilot. This article can provide positive press for the Town. Mayor Goette asked about whether the composting was a part of the recycling program. Council Member Drohan stated it is not. Composting is separate. Mayor Goette asked if this was stuff already being recycle. Council Drohan stated no, they are different. This idea is to redirect non-PPPs that goes into the landfill. The program has to at least break even. Town Administrator Milie explained the connection to water. Town Administrator Milie explained the need to collect data with the start of the program. Council Member Barbaree brought up dishwashers usually have food on dishes. Council Member Drohan would like Council to agree to bring in experts to discuss composting and to see if there is a will in the Town.

The last four years we have struggled with cost. If we have someone using high amount of water that is wasteful, they should pay more. Council Member Crenshaw asked Drohan has he put this on the priority list. Council Member Crenshaw also spoke of those stealing water. Three found illegal taps were found when doing the Bannon/Falligant line. Regency Trailer Park is another violator. Town Administrator Milie points out components of the system needing to be addressed. What is the cost of doing business? What does the system actually cost? Not a lot of cost saved for reserves. Council needs to set a reserve goal. Another component is pass through. Council Member Crenshaw stated Council discussed reviewing the rates annually. It was done by staff because it was an issue with voting or not. Council Member Drohan stated he would like to start with better billing. Crenshaw asked for Clerk of Council Denion to find the study. Town Administrator Milie asked to revisit costing in January. Inflation has really increased. It will be a lipness test. Council Williams thanked Council Member Drohan for all the work he has put into this issue. Council Member Williams stated he would like to know how would the Town cover the cost of reduction. There will need to be creative way to cover the lost revenue. Council Member Drohan stated it has to do with how water systems are run. It runs like a business. There needs to be the burden on the consumers not the citizens. Council Member Williams liked the idea on composting. Need to make it easier on the residents. Council Member Drohan stated that is what is happening right now. Collecting feedback from the voluntary program.

Mayor closes this meeting at 6:29 pm.

Mayor, Beth E. Goette

Clerk of Council, Deatre N. Denion